Bharat Jodo Yatra and Organizational Ethics

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Moral philosopher Peter Singer made a distinction between two types of ethics—obligatory and supererogatory. The first is an act where one is obligated to work because of a prior commitment or promise. In contrast, supererogatory ethics is when one demonstrates extra commitment, even though there is nothing compelling to do so. To explain further, charity for a cause is marked as supererogatory, while clocking a fixed number of hours at work is obligatory. Singer then goes on to argue that under certain conditions of duress and affluence, certain kinds of donation and charity become obligatory and not supererogatory.

Much of the Congress party's organizational culture (exemplified by the attitude of its workers and leaders) is a curious mix of both supererogatory and obligatory. On the one hand, they themselves see their contribution as a work of generosity and charity. But on the other hand, they expect quick rewards and returns. Plus, in the absence of proper organizational norms, rules of promotion and due recognition, wide-scale networking, aligning to a patronage network and going through the motions (participating in routine protests, posts on social media and other symbolic events) are seen as the only means of making it count. It is clear to any careful observer that the obligatory overwhelms the supererogatory. Consequently, there is a palpable trust deficit between party co-workers. Every worthwhile contribution (supererogatory) is seen as an existential threat to one's own growth. That is why party workers make efforts to not only make themselves visible, but also to make others invisible and discredited. These everyday machinations seem to have got institutionalized beyond